Unit 4 — Contemporary Poetry

Track E · Klasse 13 · Niveau E (Basisfach / Leistungsfach) · Abitur year

Niveau E

1. Reading

Read the text and use it for the activities below.

Reading — three poetic moves (paraphrased)

The fragmentary lyric refuses syntactic completeness; lines break off mid-thought; the white space is part of the meaning.

The document poem uses found material — court transcripts, government documents, treaty texts — and re-arranges or annotates them; the *I* is ironised.

The polyvocal lyric allows multiple speakers / voices inside a single poem, often without quote marks; the boundary between speakers is deliberately uncertain.

Vocabulary — contemporary poetic form

document poem (or documentary poetics), fragmentary lyric, prose poem, polyvocal lyric, found poem, ekphrastic poem, the broken line, the white space, polyphony, ironised I, elliptical lyric.

2. Practise

Niveau E — controlled

1. Match: document poem → uses found material; polyvocal → multiple speakers; fragmentary lyric → broken syntax + white space.
2. T or F: contemporary lyric typically uses regular meter; document poems are usually sentimental.

Niveau E — productive

3. Build 3 sentences applying contemporary-poetic vocabulary to one of the three forms.

3. Your turn

Poetic-analysis essay, 400 words. Trace the *ironised I* across the three forms. Use 4 contemporary-poetic terms + 6 academic discourse markers + 1 cleft + 1 quote per poem.

Sample

The most useful single move for reading contemporary lyric is the ironised I — the speaker who refuses to claim the unified Romantic position and whose *I* is structurally compromised. In the fragmentary lyric, the *I* is interrupted by white space: a line breaks mid-thought, and the silence that

follows is part of the speaker. *"What I wanted to say / was — "* leaves the verb open. Accordingly, the speaker becomes a person interrupted, not a person speaking. By contrast, the document poem ironises the *I* by refusing it almost entirely: court transcripts, treaty texts, and government documents replace the lyric voice. *"The party of the first part hereby agrees — "* is, in Layli Long Soldier-style work, both a quote and a confrontation. The reader is forced to read the *I*'s absence as itself a poetic move. More specifically, the polyvocal lyric ironises the *I* by multiplying it: two or more voices share the poem without quote marks, and the boundary between speakers is the formal site of meaning. *"I said. She said. We said."* — the rhythm of pronoun shift performs the polyphony. It is precisely this shared refusal — fragmentary, document-based, or polyvocal — that distinguishes post-2000 lyric from its 19th-century inheritance. In this regard, what looks like formal experimentation is structural critique: the unified Romantic *I* is treated as one historical option among others, not as the natural form of lyric voice. Caution is warranted; not every fragmented line is a fragmentary lyric. The form is a stance, not a decoration. The reader's task is to register the stance and to ask, in each case, *what would the Romantic version of this poem have lost?*. The answer, more often than not, is precisely the thing the contemporary form is preserving.

4. Further reading / listening

- Ocean Vuong, *Night Sky with Exit Wounds* (2016).
- Warsan Shire, *Bless the Daughter Raised by a Voice in Her Head* (2022).
- Layli Long Soldier, *WHEREAS* (2017).